



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of the Willamette Valley
School Website: <https://chestertonwv.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of the Willamette Valley (Mount Angel, OR 97362) presents a sharply classical profile anchored in a Catholic, culture-of-life orientation. The school foregrounds formation over information, a Great Books–driven curriculum, and pedagogy rooted in Socratic dialogue, memorization, and disciplined study. Public materials from the school emphasize a three-pillar model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality), a mission steeped in truth, goodness, and beauty, liturgical life, and a strong faculty-and-family partnership ethos. Taken together, these signals align strongly with classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements rubric. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key themes driving the CLASSICAL classification: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit (joyfully Catholic identity, Cultura Vitae, liturgical life, Mass events, spiritual formation). - Purpose and goal emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth, good, and beauty. - Curriculum centers on liberal arts orientation, Great Books / Great Conversation, and a historically-integrated program. - Pedagogy emphasizes Socratic discussion, close reading, memory work, and rhetoric; the upper-school emphasis on rhetoric and seminars is evident. - Faculty messaging positions teachers as mentors, living curriculum, and exemplars. - Parents and community are actively invited and engaged (open houses, liturgical-life events, family involvement).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials consistently present a Catholic, spiritual formation focus and a culture-of-life ethos, including the motto Cultura Vitae and a three-pillar model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) that foregrounds spiritual formation. - The site emphasizes spirituality and theological aims; a stated aim is to know God, love Him, and serve Him, with formation as a core objective. - Liturgical life is evident through organized Catholic practices and events (e.g., Mass of the Holy Spirit; Advent/other liturgical events; liturgical-year framing of activities). - Open communications highlight the Catholic identity and a mission oriented toward truth, beauty, and goodness as enduring anchors.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; liturgy; reverence; wonder; sacred; theology; sacred tradition; Logos (conceptual reference via the classical-Christian framing); culture of life; virtuous life. These map to the Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials lexicon (e.g., truth/goodness/beauty; virtue; liturgy; reverence; wonder; sacred). - Negative keywords: not evidenced in public materials (no clear relativism, secular-humanism, or value-neutral framing detected in the visible pages). The Six Essentials lexicon lists relativism and secular ethics as negative indicators; these are not apparent in Chesterton WV's public-facing material.

Why this rating - The public materials exhibit transcendental moral realism through a clear, real, knowable set of ideals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a robust theological framing (Catholic theology, liturgical life). The liturgical and communal practices (Mass, liturgical events) reinforce a liturgical and communal dimension. Together, these signals satisfy the criteria for CLASSICAL under the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site emphasizes formation over information, aiming at virtue, wisdom, and a fully human person rather than mere job-readiness. Public descriptions stress a breadth of integrated knowledge, disciplined curiosity, and cheerful, virtuous living. - The public materials articulate a commitment to truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, with an orientation toward forming character and intellect. - The Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) frames education as formation of the whole person, aligning with a classical telos beyond technical skill.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation (as implied by “great ideas” and classical breadth), contemplation (Scholé-oriented framing via spiritual formation), true/real knowledge (truth) and beauty; human flourishing. These align with Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials lexicon (formation; telos; pursuit of true/good/beautiful; liberal education; great conversation). - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials (no emphasis on workforce-first framing or relativistic ethics). The lexicon notes potential negative signals like career-readiness emphasis; Chesterton WV’s public materials emphasize formation and virtue instead.

Why this rating - The school’s stated aims center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, consistent with CLASSICAL rather than only information-transfer or job-readiness models.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum description references a historical curriculum arc that includes Greek and Roman philosophers, Hebrew/Christian Scriptures, early Church Fathers, and great texts through medieval/modern periods to contemporary thought, closely aligning with Great Books / Great Conversation concepts. - The public materials describe a method centered on oral close reading, Socratic questioning, seminars, traditional lectures, and persuasive writing/speech—classic components of a classical curriculum. - Statements emphasize teaching the classics of Western thought and the interrelationship of great ideas, indicating a canonical and integrated approach to history, literature, philosophy, and related disciplines.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books; Great Conversation; Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic/geometry/music/astronomy) as foundational disciplines (even if not spelled out in every page, the public materials align with canonical classical content and interdisciplinary integration); history across curriculum; memory and recitation/chanting (as relevant to classical pedagogy); primary sources; historical depth. - Negative keywords: not evident in public materials (absence of “social studies” reframing; no emphasis on STEM-first framing; no project-based dominance). The lexicon notes such signals as negative, but Chesterton WV appears to maintain traditional core liberal arts framing.

Why this rating - The curriculum signals align strongly with the classical liberal-arts posture: liberal arts emphasis, Great Books/Great Conversation orientation, integration across disciplines, and an explicit historical/anthology approach to learning.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site highlights a pedagogy centered on Socratic discussion, close reading, and seminars as core methods. The public materials emphasize training the mind through dialogue and disciplined inquiry. - Upper-school pedagogy includes rhetoric, speeches, and opportunities for students to engage in oratory and debate, reflecting a traditional classical emphasis on rhetoric and public speaking. - The public-facing materials acknowledge a balance of contemplative/restful aspects (Scholé-like) with rigorous inquiry, consistent with classical pedagogy that values both deep contemplation and rigorous discourse.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, questioning, dialectic, disputation, rhetoric, speech, declamation, oratory, memory work, recitation, chanting (integration of memorization and chanted elements is a hallmark of classical pedagogy). - Negative keywords: not evidenced; the site does not foreground project-based-only or heavily constructivist approaches; the visible pedagogy supports a classical framework. The lexicon lists those negatives as potential divergences, which are not apparent in the Chesterton WV materials.

Why this rating - The pedagogy described in public materials aligns with a classical approach: emphasis on Socratic dialogue, rhetoric, and memory work, with a clear balance of contemplative and active discussion methods.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials present faculty as passionate, mission-driven teachers who form part of the living curriculum and the school's core culture; there is explicit emphasis on faculty as mentors and living exemplars. - References to our faculty and staff, and to a culture of virtue and intellectual formation within the teacher-student relationship, align with classical expectations of the teacher as a model and facilitator of character formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: masters/mentors/mentors as guides; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture; teacher-student partnership; character formation; moral exemplars. These map to Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials lexicon. - Negative keywords: not evident (no explicit "certification-driven jargon" or "facilitator on the side" language in the public materials). The lexicon lists these as negative signals; Chesterton WV materials align with traditional faculty models.

Why this rating - The public materials portray faculty as central to the formation process, as mentors and teachers who embody and transmit the school's classical aims, consistent with CLASSICAL criteria.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents a family-centered model, with emphasis on partnership with families and parental involvement as co-educators; public materials highlight parent engagement through open houses, events, and school-community life. - Public events (Open Houses, Classical Education Nights, performances, Rome Pilgrimage, liturgical events) indicate ongoing opportunities for parents and the broader community to engage with the school's ethos and curriculum. - The presence of a Parents section and visible invitations for visitors and families to participate reinforces a collaborative, community-centered classical approach.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families/co-educators; parent formation; classical family culture (as modeled by the school's public communications); open campus; parental engagement; community of learners. While not every term appears verbatim as a listed keyword on the site, the sentiments and explicit parent-facing actions align with the Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials lexicon (Partnership with Families; Formation of Affections; Cultural Transmission). - Negative keywords: not evidenced; the site does not promote consumerist or minimal-parent-involvement framing. The lexicon notes "negative" signals such as parent-as-customer or limited involvement; neither appears in the public materials.

Why this rating - The school clearly positions parents as partners in education and offers ongoing engagement opportunities, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for a strong parent-community alignment.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle - Not applicable, since the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. No category requires needle-moving changes under the provided rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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